

See also: The Glorious Revolution and the English Bill of Rights 102–103 ■ The US Constitution and Bill of Rights 110–117
■ The Declaration of the Rights of Man 118–119 ■ The Treaty of Versailles 192–193

become the Soviet secret police, or KGB. The following spring, as civil war continued to rage, they created a new constitution. The Constitution of 1918 was the first to recognize rule by the working class, making Russia the first-ever socialist state.

The constitution

When Lenin drew up a constitution, adopted in 1918, it was not intended to ensure stability with checks and balances, but was a revolutionary blueprint for changing society.

The constitution's aim was “the abolition of the exploitation of men by men, the entire abolition of the division of the people into classes, the suppression of exploiters, the establishment of a socialist society.” An alliance of workers and peasants would rule the country through soviets—councils of workers’ and soldiers’ deputies that had sprung up all over Russia.

Initially, soviets had been open to all, but the constitution excluded the bourgeoisie from soviets and all other organs of government. It also forbade anyone from supporting the



anti-revolutionary White Army (led by the former imperial military) and made it the duty of workers and soldiers to join the new Red Army.

The Bolsheviks’ attachment to power lasted beyond the Civil War; the 1918 Constitution replaced the czar’s despotism with the state despotism of what would become

This striking Soviet poster, issued to commemorate the 1917 Revolution, depicts a worker smashing the chains of oppression to win peace, freedom, socialism, and democracy.

the Russian Communist Party. Significantly, it did not include a guarantee of human rights for individuals.

The Russian Congress of Soviets, which had formed in 1917, was filled with soviet deputies, elected workers, peasants, and soldiers, but in reality it was just a rubber stamp for the Party. The “supreme organ of power,” the Central Executive Committee, selected the head of state and issued decrees. Commissars elected by Congress also issued decrees and saw to administration.

The Constitution of 1918 laid out the principles for constitutions that would later be adopted throughout the communist world—in Belarus, China, Cuba, Turkmenistan, North Korea, and Vietnam. It also provided a framework for the USSR government for 73 years. ■

Vladimir Ilich Lenin

Vladimir Ulyanov, better known as Lenin, was born in Simbirsk (now Ulyanovsk) in 1870. Lenin turned his thoughts toward revolution in part due to the hanging of his elder brother in 1887 for his role in a plot to assassinate Czar Alexander III.

Lenin, inspired by the French revolutionary constitution, the Paris Commune, and Karl Marx, went on to shape the Russian Revolution. He was determined to make the Revolution last by founding a party. As he had said

in 1902, “Give us an organization of revolutionaries and we will overturn Russia!” However, the Russian Social-Democratic Workers’ Party (RSDWP) split into hard-line Bolsheviks and more moderate Mensheviks.

Lenin’s dynamism and inspirational leadership took the Bolsheviks into power in Russia by the end of 1917 and ensured that there was no way back for Czar Nicholas II. The Bolsheviks became the Russian Communist Party and Lenin became the first head of the Soviet state, until his death in 1924.

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Democracy for an insignificant minority, democracy for the rich—that is the democracy of capitalist society.

Vladimir Lenin

The State and Revolution, 1917

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